

RentalPro

Digital Rental Management System

IT402 — DELIVERABLE 1

Complete Project Report

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Chapter 1: Introduction

Note: Chapters 1–7 and Appendices A–B record RentalPro as it stood when they were written, after IT401 Deliverable 3, and every figure in them (93 tests, 77% coverage, 31 templates) is that of the system at that time. Appendix C summarises everything added since — the eleven gaps closed for IT402 Deliverable 2, the billing engine, the redesigned Harare interface, English, Shona and Arabic, production hardening and deployment to Render — with today's figures (18 tables, 305 tests, 86% coverage).

1.1 Background

Small and mid-sized property owners and managers commonly track tenants, rent payments, and maintenance work through a mixture of spreadsheets, paper files, and ad-hoc messaging. As a portfolio grows past a handful of units, this manual approach becomes error-prone: rent due dates are missed, maintenance requests are lost between a phone call and a follow-up, and there is no single place to see which units are occupied, which tenants are behind on rent, or how much a property earned last month.

RentalPro was conceived to replace that fragmented workflow with a single, role-aware web application that a Property Owner, a Property Manager, a Tenant, and a Maintenance Staff member can all use for their part of the rental lifecycle — from listing a property, to onboarding a tenant and activating a lease, to collecting rent and resolving a maintenance ticket.

1.2 Problem Statement

Property owners operating small-to-mid-sized rental portfolios (1–500 units) lack an affordable, purpose-built system that unifies four things that are currently handled separately: property and unit records, tenant and lease records, rent collection and arrears tracking, and maintenance request handling. The absence of a unified system causes:

- Missed or late rent reminders because no system tracks due dates automatically.
- No single source of truth for who owes what, across how many properties.
- Maintenance requests that are reported verbally and easily forgotten or duplicated.
- No audit trail of who changed what, which matters when a payment or a lease term is disputed.
- No role separation — anyone with access to the spreadsheet can see and edit everything, regardless of whether they are the owner, a manager, or a tenant.

1.3 Objectives

General objective: Design, build, and test a web-based Rental Management System that digitises the full rental lifecycle — property listing, tenant records, rent tracking, and maintenance requests — for four operational user roles plus an administrator.

Specific objectives:

- Analyse the domain and produce a Software Requirements Specification covering functional and non-functional requirements (IT401 Deliverable 1).
- Design the system's object-oriented structure and relational database schema (IT401 Deliverable 2).
- Implement a working application covering all 25 identified use cases across 5 user roles (IT401 Deliverable 3).

- Verify the implementation with an automated test suite covering business logic, authentication/authorisation, end-to-end feature flows, scheduled jobs, and input validation.
- Document the finished system in a complete project report covering the analysis, design, database, development, and testing performed, plus installation and user documentation (this document, IT402 Deliverable 1).

1.4 Scope

RentalPro covers four functional modules, consistent with the scope defined in the Software Requirements Specification (IT401 Deliverable 1):

Module	Description
Property Listing	Register properties, manage unit details, track occupancy status
Tenant Records	Onboard tenants, upload lease documents, maintain contact and history
Rent Tracking	Record rent payments, generate due-date alerts, produce statements
Maintenance Requests	Submit, assign, track, and close maintenance work orders

The system targets small-to-mid-sized property management operations (1 to 500 units) and is not a public property marketplace, nor does it handle real-estate transactions or mortgage processing.

1.5 Limitations

This report documents the system as actually implemented and tested, including known simplifications made against the original design in IT401 Deliverable 2, in the interest of a working, honestly-assessed deliverable rather than an aspirational one:

- File storage is local disk in development; the design supports swapping in AWS S3 for production but this has not been implemented or tested.
- PDF generation uses reportlab rather than the originally specified WeasyPrint, to avoid native system dependencies in the Docker image — the generated documents (rent statements, property reports) are equivalent in content.
- Payment, email, and SMS integrations (Stripe, SendGrid, Twilio) run in a dev-mode fallback unless real API keys are supplied; this was a deliberate choice so the whole system, including its automated test suite, runs fully offline.
- Multi-currency and multi-language (Arabic/English) support described in the SRS is represented in the data model (currency per property) but a translated UI was not implemented.
- No formal database migration history (Alembic) has been generated; schema changes during development were applied via SQLAlchemy's `create_all()`.

1.6 Project Overview

RentalPro is a server-rendered Flask web application backed by a relational database (SQLite in development and test, PostgreSQL in Docker/production). It supports five roles — Property Owner, Property Manager, Tenant, Maintenance Staff, and Administrator — each with a role-specific dashboard

and a restricted set of actions enforced both by route-level guards and by data-level ownership checks. The remaining chapters of this report cover the analysis (Chapter 2), design (Chapters 3–4), implementation (Chapter 5), and verification (Chapter 6) of the system, followed by a conclusion (Chapter 7) and three appendices covering installation, day-to-day use, and what has changed since the main chapters were written.

Chapter 2: Object-Oriented Analysis

2.1 Overview

This chapter analyses the RentalPro domain in object-oriented terms: who the system's actors are, what they need to accomplish (its use cases), and what real-world concepts (candidate objects) the system must model. It condenses and confirms the analysis first carried out in the Software Requirements Specification (IT401 Deliverable 1), cross-checked against what was actually implemented and tested.

2.2 System Actors

RentalPro recognises five actors. Four are human roles with a dashboard and permitted actions; the fifth (System/Scheduler) is an automated actor that triggers time-based use cases without a human present.

Actor	Description	Primary Use Cases
Property Owner	Ultimate account holder; owns one or more properties; full management access, exclusive right to create new properties	UC-03 to UC-06, UC-24, UC-25
Property Manager	Day-to-day operational user acting on the owner's behalf; same access as Owner except cannot create new properties	UC-04 to UC-22
Tenant	Renter occupying a unit; self-service portal only — own lease, own payments, own maintenance requests	UC-10, UC-13, UC-17, UC-18, UC-21
Maintenance Staff	Technician who executes assigned work orders; queue-only access	UC-20
System / Scheduler	Automated actor; runs the four background jobs on a daily schedule	UC-11, UC-14, UC-15, UC-23

An Administrator role also exists at the data-access level (bypasses ownership checks everywhere) but has no use cases of its own in the current implementation beyond the management actions already listed for Owner/Manager.

2.3 Use Case Model

Twenty-five use cases were identified across the four functional modules plus authentication and reporting. Every use case listed below has a corresponding route (or scheduled job) in the implementation and at least one automated test — see Chapter 6 for the verification evidence and Section 5.4 for the exact route mapping.

UC	Name	Primary Actor	Module
UC-01	Register Account / Login	All Users	Authentication
UC-02	Manage User Roles & Permissions (RBAC)	System Admin	Authentication

UC	Name	Primary Actor	Module
UC-03	Add New Property	Property Owner	Property Listing
UC-04	Add / Edit Unit	Owner / Manager	Property Listing
UC-05	View Property Dashboard	Owner / Manager	Property Listing
UC-06	Archive Property / Unit	Owner / Manager	Property Listing
UC-07	Create Tenant Profile	Property Manager	Tenant Records
UC-08	Invite Tenant via Link	Property Manager	Tenant Records
UC-09	Upload Lease Document	Property Manager	Tenant Records
UC-10	View Lease and Profile	Tenant	Tenant Records
UC-11	Send Lease Expiry Alert	System	Tenant Records
UC-12	Record Rent Payment	Property Manager	Rent Tracking
UC-13	Pay Rent Online	Tenant	Rent Tracking
UC-14	Send Rent Due Alert	System	Rent Tracking
UC-15	Send Overdue Notification	System	Rent Tracking
UC-16	Generate Rent Statement	Property Manager	Rent Tracking
UC-17	View Rent History	Tenant / Manager	Rent Tracking
UC-18	Submit Maintenance Request	Tenant	Maintenance
UC-19	Assign Maintenance Request	Property Manager	Maintenance
UC-20	Update Request Status	Maintenance Staff	Maintenance
UC-21	Confirm / Reopen Request	Tenant	Maintenance
UC-22	Log Maintenance Cost	Property Manager	Maintenance
UC-23	Escalate Overdue Request	System	Maintenance
UC-24	Generate Property Performance Report	Owner / Manager	Reporting
UC-25	Export Report (PDF / JSON)	Owner / Manager	Reporting

2.3.1 Detailed Use Case — UC-09: Upload Lease Document

Field	Description
Actors	Property Manager (primary)
Preconditions	Manager is logged in; tenant profile exists; a signed lease PDF is ready for upload
Trigger	Manager clicks "Upload Lease Document" from a

Field	Description
	tenant's profile
Main Flow	1. Manager selects a vacant unit. 2. Manager enters lease dates, monthly rent, deposit, and due day. 3. Manager uploads the signed PDF. 4. System validates the file is a genuine PDF (magic-byte check) and the dates are consistent. 5. System creates the Lease record and sets the unit to Occupied. 6. System emails the tenant a confirmation.
Exception Flow	Non-PDF or oversized file is rejected before any record is created; a unit already leased to a different active tenant blocks the upload.
Postconditions	Lease is ACTIVE; unit status is OCCUPIED; lease appears in the tenant's rent history going forward.
Verified by	tests/test_routes.py — test_upload_lease_sets_unit_occupied, test_upload_lease_rejects_non_pdf

2.3.2 Detailed Use Case — UC-13: Pay Rent Online

Field	Description
Actors	Tenant (primary), Payment Gateway (secondary)
Preconditions	Tenant is logged in with an active lease and an outstanding balance
Trigger	Tenant clicks "Pay Now" in the portal
Main Flow	1. System shows the current balance. 2. Tenant confirms payment. 3. System creates a checkout session with the payment gateway (or a simulated dev-mode session when no live key is configured). 4. Gateway confirms success via redirect/webhook. 5. System records the payment idempotently against the gateway reference and recalculates the balance. 6. System emails a receipt to the tenant and notifies the property owner.
Exception Flow	A retried webhook with the same gateway reference does not create a second payment (idempotency); a tampered or replayed webhook signature is rejected.
Postconditions	Balance is reduced by the payment amount; a receipt number is issued; the payment is visible in the tenant's rent history.
Verified by	tests/test_routes.py — test_pay_rent_online_dev_mode_end_to_end; tests/test_validation.py — Stripe signature and idempotency tests

2.3.3 Detailed Use Case — UC-18/UC-19/UC-20/UC-21: Maintenance Request Lifecycle

These four use cases form one continuous workflow and were analysed together because they share a single state machine on MaintenanceRequest: SUBMITTED → ASSIGNED → IN_PROGRESS → COMPLETED → CLOSED, with a REOPEN transition back to SUBMITTED.

Step	Actor	Action	Resulting Status
1	Tenant	Submits a request with title, category, and severity	SUBMITTED
2	Property Manager	Assigns the request to a Maintenance Staff member with a target date	ASSIGNED
3	Maintenance Staff	Marks work as started	IN_PROGRESS
4	Maintenance Staff	Marks work as completed, with notes	COMPLETED
5a	Tenant	Confirms resolution (optionally rates 1–5)	CLOSED
5b	Tenant	Reopens with a reason instead	SUBMITTED (cycle repeats)

An Emergency-severity request additionally triggers an immediate SMS to the property owner at submission time, and the automated escalation job (UC-23) flags any request whose target date has passed.

2.4 Non-Functional Requirements Analysis

The functional analysis above is paired with the non-functional requirements from IT401 Deliverable 1, grouped into the categories the implementation addresses directly:

Category	Requirement (from SRS) → How it was analysed for design
Security	Passwords must be hashed, sessions must expire, RBAC must be enforced per role, and a user must never read another user's data — drove the design of a single role_required() decorator plus a separate per-resource assert_owner()/assert_tenant_self() check (Chapter 3).
Reliability	Payment records must be immutable and auditable — drove the append-only AuditLog table and the decision never to UPDATE or DELETE a RentPayment row (Chapter 4).
Performance	Dashboard and listing pages must load quickly under normal load — drove the indexing strategy in Chapter 4 (composite indexes on the columns every dashboard query filters by).
Usability	A manager must be able to add a property and unit without training; a tenant must be able to submit a request in minutes — drove the flat, role-scoped

Category	Requirement (from SRS) → How it was analysed for design
	navigation described in Appendix B.
Scalability	The design should not need architectural change up to 100,000 units — drove the choice of UUID primary keys (safe under distributed/concurrent inserts) over auto-increment integers.

2.5 Domain (Conceptual Class) Analysis

Reading the use cases and requirements for candidate nouns yields the following analysis-level classes, later refined into the 13 implementation classes documented in Chapter 3:

Candidate Class	Responsibility
User	Authenticate; hold identity and role
Property	Group units under one owner; report occupancy
Unit	The rentable thing; know its own status and current lease
Tenant	Renter-specific profile data, linked one-to-one to a User
Lease	The contract; know how much is owed as of any date
RentPayment	An immutable record of money received
MaintenanceRequest	A ticket; own its lifecycle state and cost total
Notification	A record that a message was (or should be) sent
AuditLog	An immutable record that something happened

Two further analysis classes — TenantInvitation and PasswordReset — emerged not from the SRS's nouns directly but from its stated business rules (a 48-hour invitation window, a time-limited password reset link) once those rules were modelled as first-class, expiring tokens rather than fields bolted onto User. This refinement step is carried into the design in Chapter 3.

Chapter 3: Object-Oriented Design

3.1 Architectural Style

RentalPro is a server-rendered, layered web application: a Flask application factory (backend/___init___py) wires together a presentation layer of Jinja2 templates, an application layer of nine route Blueprints, a domain/service layer of pure-Python modules, and a data layer of thirteen SQLAlchemy models. This is a deliberate departure from the micro-service-oriented architecture sketched in IT401 Deliverable 2 (separate PropertyService, TenantService, etc. behind an API gateway): for a single-deployment application of this size, a layered monolith is simpler to build, test, and reason about, while still keeping each concern in its own module. Figure 1 shows the architecture as implemented.

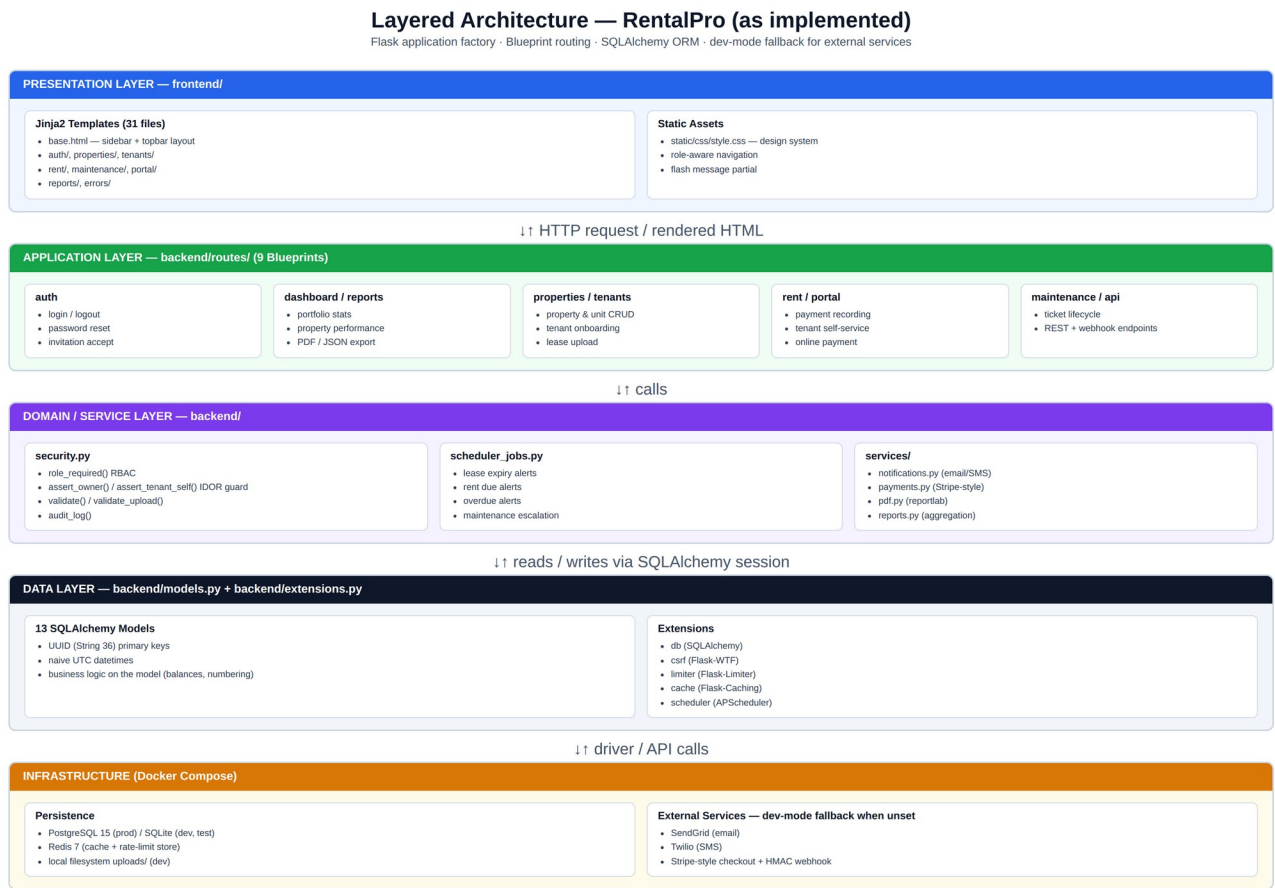


Figure 1: Layered Architecture — RentalPro (as implemented)

3.2 Design Patterns Used

Pattern	Where	Why
Application Factory	backend/___init___py — create_app()	Allows a fresh app instance per test (TestConfig) without global state leaking between tests
Blueprint (Front Controller / MVC-ish)	backend/routes/*.py — 9 blueprints	Groups related routes and keeps each module’s view functions independent and separately testable

Pattern	Where	Why
Decorator	security.py — login_required, role_required(*roles)	Cross-cutting authentication/authorisation applied declaratively on top of a view function
Active Record	models.py — e.g. Lease.balance, Property.occupancy_rate	Business logic (balance calculation, occupancy) lives on the model that owns the data, not scattered across routes
Strategy (implicit)	services/notifications.py, services/payments.py	send_email()/send_sms()/create_checkout_session() pick a live-provider or dev-mode code path at call time without the caller knowing which
Guard Clause	security.py — assert_owner(), assert_tenant_self()	IDOR protection expressed as an early abort(403) rather than nested conditionals in every view
Idempotent Receiver	services/payments.py — record_idempotent_payment()	A retried webhook call is safe to repeat; keyed on RentPayment.gateway_ref

3.3 Package Structure

The application is organised as a Python package rather than the single 2,800-line file originally sketched in the IT401 Deliverable 3 plan, for maintainability and to keep each blueprint independently testable:

Path	Responsibility
backend/__init__.py	create_app() factory; extension init; blueprint registration; error handlers; CLI commands; scheduler wiring
backend/config.py	Config / TestConfig classes
backend/extensions.py	Shared db, csrf, limiter, cache, scheduler singletons
backend/models.py	13 SQLAlchemy models and their business-logic methods
backend/security.py	Session auth, role_required(), IDOR guards, validate(), validate_upload(), audit_log()
backend/scheduler_jobs.py	The four APScheduler background jobs
backend/seed.py	Demo data matching the credentials in Appendix A
backend/routes/	9 blueprints: auth, dashboard, properties, tenants, rent, portal, maintenance, reports, api
backend/services/	notifications.py, payments.py, pdf.py, reports.py
frontend/templates/	31 Jinja2 templates
frontend/static/	style.css design system
tests/	5 test modules, 93 tests (Chapter 6)

3.4 Class Diagram

Figure 2 shows the thirteen domain classes that back the database schema in Chapter 4, each drawn with its key attributes and behaviour. Attributes prefixed with FK are foreign keys; methods in italics are Python @property accessors rather than stored fields.

UML Class Diagram — RentalPro Domain Model
13 SQLAlchemy model classes (backend/models.py). See Section 3.4 for the full relationship & multiplicity table.



Figure 2: UML Class Diagram — RentalPro Domain Model

3.4.1 Class Relationships and Multiplicity

Relationship	Multiplicity	Notes
User ↔ Tenant	1 : 0..1	A Tenant profile extends exactly one User; not every User is a Tenant
User (owner) → Property	1 : 0..*	One owner may hold many properties
Property → Unit	1 : 1..*	Composition — a Unit cannot exist without its Property
Unit → Lease	1 : 0..*	Historical leases retained; at most one is ACTIVE at a time (enforced by application logic, not a DB constraint)
Tenant → Lease	1 : 0..*	A tenant accumulates leases over time
Lease → RentPayment	1 : 0..*	Payments are immutable once

Relationship	Multiplicity	Notes
		created
Unit → MaintenanceRequest	1 : 0..*	A unit may have many requests, open or closed
Tenant → MaintenanceRequest	1 : 0..*	The tenant who filed the request
User (staff) → MaintenanceRequest	0..1 : 0..*	assigned_to is nullable until UC-19 assigns it
MaintenanceRequest → MaintenanceCost	1 : 0..*	One or more cost line items per completed job
MaintenanceRequest → MaintenanceNote	1 : 0..*	Work-log entries
Unit → TenantInvitation	1 : 0..*	Re-inviting a unit supersedes its previous open invitation
User → Notification / PasswordReset / AuditLog	1 : 0..*	Every dispatched message, reset token, and audit entry belongs to exactly one user (AuditLog.user_id is nullable for scheduler-originated entries)

3.5 Interaction Design — Sequence of Key Operations

Rather than a boxes-and-lifelines sequence diagram, the two most technically significant flows are documented below as numbered message sequences, which is how they were actually implemented and verified against.

3.5.1 Sequence — Pay Rent Online (UC-13)

#	From → To	Message
1	Tenant → Portal Route	GET /portal/pay
2	Portal Route → Lease	lease.balance
3	Portal Route → Tenant	render balance + "Pay Now" button
4	Tenant → Portal Route	POST /portal/pay
5	Portal Route → payments.create_checkout_session()	amount = lease.balance
6	payments service → Stripe (or dev-mode)	create PaymentIntent / simulated session
7	Portal Route → Tenant	302 redirect to checkout_url
8	Gateway → API Blueprint	POST /api/v1/webhooks/stripe (HMAC-signed)
9	API Blueprint → payments.verify_stripe_signature()	validate t=ts,v1=sig, reject if >300s old
10	API Blueprint → payments.record_idempotent_pay	insert RentPayment keyed on gateway_ref

#	From → To	Message
	ment()	
11	API Blueprint → notifications service	email receipt to tenant + notify owner

3.5.2 Sequence — Submit & Assign Maintenance Request (UC-18 & UC-19)

#	From → To	Message
1	Tenant → Maintenance Blueprint	GET /maintenance/add
2	Tenant → Maintenance Blueprint	POST /maintenance/add (title, category, severity)
3	Route → MaintenanceRequest	generate_ticket_number() → MNT-YYYYMMDD-XXXX
4	Route → notifications service	email tenant (confirmation) + email owner (new request)
5	Route → notifications service	if severity == EMERGENCY: also SMS the owner
6	Manager → Maintenance Blueprint	POST /maintenance/<id>/update (action=assign, staff_id, target_date)
7	Route → MaintenanceRequest	status = ASSIGNED; assigned_to = staff_id
8	Route → notifications service	email staff member (assignment) + email tenant (status update)
9	Route → AuditLog	audit_log("maintenance_assigned", ...)

3.6 Activity Design — Maintenance Request Lifecycle

The state machine behind UC-18-UC-21 (Section 2.3.3) is enforced entirely in one route handler, `maintenance.update()`, which reads an action field (assign, start, complete, close, reopen) and applies the corresponding guard and state transition. This keeps the whole lifecycle's business rules in one place rather than spread across five separate endpoints.

Action	Allowed From	Guard	Resulting Status
assign	SUBMITTED, ACKNOWLEDGED, ASSIGNED	caller role ∈ {Owner, Manager, Admin}	ASSIGNED
start	ASSIGNED	caller is the assigned Maintenance Staff member	IN_PROGRESS
complete	IN_PROGRESS	caller is the assigned Maintenance Staff member	COMPLETED
close	COMPLETED (or any, for a manager force-close)	caller is the filing tenant, or a	CLOSED

Action	Allowed From	Guard	Resulting Status
		manager/owner/admin	
reopen	COMPLETED	caller is the filing tenant; requires a reason	SUBMITTED

3.7 Design Decisions and Rationale

Decision	Rationale
UUID (String 36) primary keys instead of auto-increment integers	Safe under concurrent/distributed inserts; does not leak record counts or sequence via the URL
Business logic (balance, occupancy, numbering) lives on the model, not the route	Keeps the same calculation reachable from a route, a scheduled job, and a test without duplication
One <code>role_required()</code> decorator plus a separate resource-level ownership check	Role alone is not enough — RBAC answers "can a Manager see properties at all?"; <code>assert_owner()</code> answers "can this Manager see this property?" (the IDOR case)
Notifications always write a Notification row, even in dev mode	The row (and its SENT/FAILED status) is what the test suite and the audit trail rely on, independent of whether a real provider was called
Payments are never UPDATED or DELETED	Matches NFR requirement for an immutable, auditable financial record; a correction is a new adjusting entry, not an edit

Chapter 4: Database Design

4.1 Database Technology

RentalPro uses SQLite for development and for the automated test suite (an isolated in-memory database per test, see Chapter 6) and PostgreSQL 15 in the Docker Compose deployment. Both are accessed through the same SQLAlchemy models with no code branching by database — a deliberate constraint on the schema design (Section 4.3) so the two environments stay behaviourally identical.

4.2 Entity Relationship Diagram

Figure 3 shows all thirteen tables with their primary and foreign keys. Full cardinalities are given in the table that follows it (Section 4.4), and the complete column-level schema is given in Section 4.5.

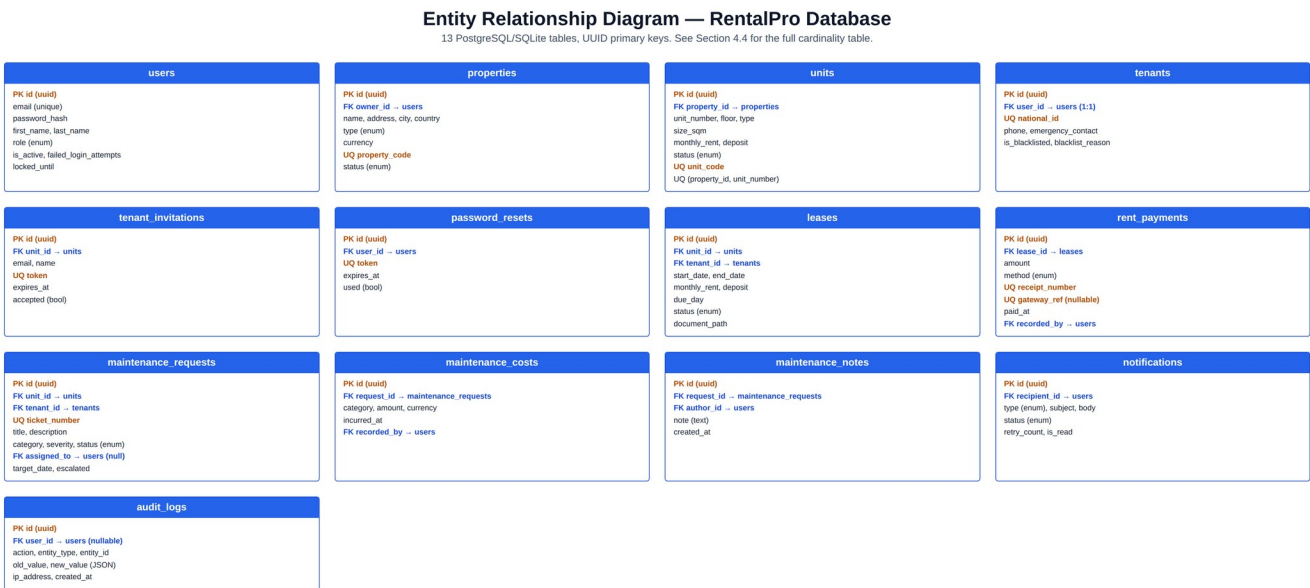


Figure 3: Entity Relationship Diagram — RentalPro Database

4.3 Schema Design Decisions

Decision	Detail
UUID primary keys	Every table uses a String(36) column storing str(uuid.uuid4()) rather than a native PostgreSQL UUID type or an auto-increment integer, so the identical schema works unmodified on SQLite (test/dev) and PostgreSQL (prod)
Naive UTC datetimes	All timestamps are stored as naive Python datetime.utcnow() values rather than timezone-aware TIMESTAMPTZ, avoiding a class of naive/aware comparison bugs across the two database backends
Soft status fields, not physical deletes	Property.status, Unit.status, Lease.status, MaintenanceRequest.status all move through an enumerated set of string values (e.g. ACTIVE → ARCHIVED) rather than being DELETED, preserving

Decision	Detail
	history for reporting and audit
Immutable payments	RentPayment rows are only ever INSERTed; a correction is a new adjusting entry, never an UPDATE, matching the audit requirement in the SRS
JSON columns for audit diffs	AuditLog.old_value / new_value are generic JSON columns so any entity's before/after state can be captured without a schema migration
Enumerated values as plain strings, not native ENUM types	role, status, type, category, severity, and method columns are validated in the application layer (security.validate(), and whitelists in each route) rather than as PostgreSQL-native ENUM types, again to keep the SQLite and PostgreSQL schemas identical

4.4 Entity Summary and Cardinalities

Table	Purpose	Key Relationships
users	Every login-capable person: owners, managers, tenants, staff, admins	1 user → 0..1 tenant profile; 1 user (owner) → 0..* properties
properties	A building or land parcel owned by one user	1 property → 1..* units
units	An individual rentable space within a property	1 unit → 0..* leases (history); 1 unit → 0..* maintenance_requests
tenants	Renter-specific profile, extending exactly one user	1 tenant → 0..* leases; 1 tenant → 0..* maintenance_requests
tenant_invitations	48-hour self-registration tokens for a specific vacant unit	1 unit → 0..* invitations (only one unexpired/unaccepted at a time by business rule)
password_resets	1-hour password-reset tokens, kept separate from users	1 user → 0..* reset tokens
leases	The contract linking one tenant to one unit for a date range	1 lease → 0..* rent_payments
rent_payments	An immutable record of money received against a lease	each row belongs to exactly 1 lease and was recorded by exactly 1 user
maintenance_requests	A ticket with a full lifecycle (Section 3.6)	1 request → 0..* maintenance_costs; 1 request → 0..* maintenance_notes
maintenance_costs	One cost line item (labour, materials, contractor...) against a request	each row belongs to exactly 1 request
maintenance_notes	A work-log entry against a request	each row belongs to exactly 1 request and 1 author
notifications	Every email/SMS dispatch attempt	each row belongs to exactly 1

Table	Purpose	Key Relationships
	and its outcome	recipient user
audit_logs	An immutable, append-only history of state-changing actions	user_id is nullable (background-job-originated entries record "scheduler" as the actor)

4.5 Table Definitions

The definitions below reflect backend/models.py exactly, as created by SQLAlchemy on both database backends.

4.5.1 users

Column	Type	Constraints
id	String(36)	PK, default uuid4
email	String(255)	NOT NULL, UNIQUE, indexed
password_hash	String(255)	NOT NULL — pbkdf2:sha256, 600,000 iterations
first_name, last_name	String(100)	NOT NULL
role	String(30)	NOT NULL — one of ADMIN, PROPERTY_OWNER, PROPERTY_MANAGER, MAINTENANCE_STAFF, TENANT
is_active	Boolean	NOT NULL, default true
failed_login_attempts	Integer	NOT NULL, default 0
locked_until	DateTime	nullable
opt_out_sms, opt_out_email	Boolean	NOT NULL, default false
created_at	DateTime	NOT NULL, default now

4.5.2 properties

Column	Type	Constraints
id	String(36)	PK
owner_id	String(36)	FK → users.id, NOT NULL, indexed
name, address, city, country	String	NOT NULL
type	String(20)	RESIDENTIAL COMMERCIAL MIXED, default RESIDENTIAL
currency	String(3)	NOT NULL, default USD
description	Text	nullable
property_code	String(20)	NOT NULL, UNIQUE — format PROP-XXXX
status	String(20)	ACTIVE ARCHIVED, default ACTIVE
created_at	DateTime	NOT NULL, default now

4.5.3 units

Column	Type	Constraints
id	String(36)	PK
property_id	String(36)	FK → properties.id, NOT NULL
unit_number	String(20)	NOT NULL
floor	String(10)	nullable
type	String(20)	STUDIO 1BR 2BR 3BR SHOP OFFICE
size_sqm	Float	nullable
monthly_rent	Float	NOT NULL
deposit	Float	NOT NULL, default 0
status	String(20)	VACANT OCCUPIED UNDER_MAINTENANCE ARCHIVED
unit_code	String(30)	NOT NULL, UNIQUE
created_at	DateTime	NOT NULL
— constraint —		UNIQUE (property_id, unit_number); INDEX (property_id, status)

4.5.4 tenants

Column	Type	Constraints
id	String(36)	PK
user_id	String(36)	FK → users.id, NOT NULL, UNIQUE (1:1)
national_id	String(50)	NOT NULL, UNIQUE
phone	String(30)	nullable
emergency_contact	String(200)	nullable
is_blacklisted	Boolean	NOT NULL, default false
blacklist_reason	String(300)	nullable
created_at	DateTime	NOT NULL

4.5.5 leases

Column	Type	Constraints
id	String(36)	PK
unit_id	String(36)	FK → units.id, NOT NULL
tenant_id	String(36)	FK → tenants.id, NOT NULL
start_date, end_date	Date	NOT NULL
monthly_rent, deposit	Float	NOT NULL

Column	Type	Constraints
due_day	Integer	NOT NULL, default 1 (1–31, clipped per month)
status	String(20)	ACTIVE TERMINATED EXPIRED
document_path	String(500)	nullable — path to the stored lease PDF
created_at	DateTime	NOT NULL
— indexes —		(unit_id, status); (tenant_id, end_date, status)

4.5.6 rent_payments, maintenance_requests, and remaining tables

The remaining seven tables (rent_payments, tenant_invitations, password_resets, maintenance_requests, maintenance_costs, maintenance_notes, notifications, audit_logs) follow the same pattern and are summarised in the ERD (Figure 3) and the entity summary (Section 4.4); their exact column definitions are given in full in backend/models.py, referenced here rather than duplicated, since the class diagram in Section 3.4 already lists every attribute for each of these classes.

4.6 Indexes

Table	Index Columns	Purpose
users	email (unique)	Login lookup
properties	owner_id	Dashboard: list an owner's properties
units	property_id, status	Occupancy queries per property
leases	unit_id, status	Find a unit's active lease
leases	tenant_id	A tenant's lease history
leases	end_date, status	Lease-expiry scheduler query (UC-11)
rent_payments	lease_id, paid_at	A lease's payment history, in order
maintenance_requests	assigned_to, status	A staff member's work queue
maintenance_requests	target_date, status	Overdue-maintenance scheduler query (UC-23)
notifications	recipient_id, status	A user's pending/unread notifications
audit_logs	entity_type, entity_id	Entity-level history lookup
audit_logs	user_id, created_at	A user's activity timeline

4.7 Referential Integrity

Foreign keys are enforced by SQLAlchemy relationships with cascade rules chosen per table:

- Property → Unit, MaintenanceRequest → MaintenanceCost, MaintenanceRequest → MaintenanceNote: CASCADE — deleting the parent removes its children (in practice, parents are archived rather than deleted, so this rarely fires in production use).

- User → Tenant: CASCADE, since a Tenant profile has no meaning without its User.
- All other foreign keys default to RESTRICT — a Unit with active Leases, or a Lease with RentPayments, cannot be deleted out from under them; the application enforces this at the business-rule level too (Section 3.7 and UC-06's exception flow in the SRS).

Chapter 5: Software Development

5.1 Technology Stack

Layer	Choice
Language	Python 3.12
Web framework	Flask 3.1 (application factory pattern)
ORM	Flask-SQLAlchemy — 13 models, UUID primary keys
Database	SQLite (dev/test) → PostgreSQL 15 (Docker/production)
Auth / Security	Werkzeug pbkdf2:sha256 (600,000 iterations); CSRF via Flask-WTF; RBAC via role_required()
Rate limiting	Flask-Limiter
Caching	Flask-Caching (SimpleCache dev, Redis in Docker)
Scheduler	APScheduler — 4 cron-style jobs
Email / SMS	SendGrid / Twilio, with an offline dev-mode fallback
Payments	Stripe-style dev-mode checkout + custom HMAC webhook verification
PDF export	reportlab (pure Python, no native system libraries)
Testing	pytest + pytest-cov
Deployment	Docker + docker-compose (Flask/Gunicorn + PostgreSQL + Redis); GitHub Actions CI

5.2 Development Methodology

Development followed an iterative, test-driven cycle rather than a single big-bang implementation: each use case was built as a vertical slice (model fields → route → template → test) and verified against the running application before moving to the next, using the application's own test client to exercise real HTTP requests end to end (login, form submission, redirect, and the resulting database state) rather than only unit-testing isolated functions. Section 5.8 below documents two implementation defects this process actually caught, and how they were fixed.

5.3 Application Factory and Configuration

The application is constructed by a single `create_app(config_class)` factory, which allows the exact same codebase to run three different ways: the interactive dev server (`python app.py`), the test suite (a fresh app and an in-memory database per test), and the production Gunicorn/Docker deployment — differing only in which Config subclass is passed in.

```
def create_app(config_class=Config):
    app = Flask(__name__, template_folder=..., static_folder=...)
    app.config.from_object(config_class)
    db.init_app(app); csrf.init_app(app); cache.init_app(app)
    if app.config["RATELIMIT_ENABLED"]: limiter.init_app(app)
    for bp in ALL_BLUEPRINTS: app.register_blueprint(bp)
```

```
... # error handlers, /health, CLI commands, scheduler wiring
return app
```

5.4 Route-to-Use-Case Mapping

Every use case from Chapter 2 maps onto exactly one blueprint route (or, for the four system-triggered use cases, one scheduler job function):

UC	Route(s) / Job
UC-01	/login, /logout
UC-02	role_required() applied to every protected route
UC-03	/properties/add
UC-04	/properties/<id>/add-unit
UC-05	/dashboard, /api/v1/dashboard-stats
UC-06	/properties/<id>/archive, /properties/<id>/units/<id>/archive
UC-07	/tenants/add
UC-08	/tenants/invite, /register/invitation/<token>
UC-09	/tenants/<id>/upload-lease
UC-10	/portal
UC-11	job_lease_expiry_alerts()
UC-12	/rent/record
UC-13	/portal/pay, /api/v1/webhooks/stripe
UC-14	job_rent_due_alerts()
UC-15	job_overdue_alerts()
UC-16	/rent/<id>/statement, /rent/<id>/statement.pdf
UC-17	/rent/<id>/history, /portal/history
UC-18	/maintenance/add
UC-19	/maintenance/<id>/update (action=assign)
UC-20	/maintenance/<id>/update (action=start/complete)
UC-21	/maintenance/<id>/update (action=close/reopen)
UC-22	/maintenance/<id>/costs/add
UC-23	job_escalate_overdue_maintenance()
UC-24	/reports
UC-25	/reports/export.pdf, /api/v1/reports/export

5.5 Key Algorithms

5.5.1 Recurring Rent Due-Date Calculation

The core billing calculation — how much rent is owed as of any date — has to cope with two edge cases: a lease that starts mid-month (its first due date is not the start date), and a due_day near the end of the month falling in a shorter month (e.g. due_day=31 in February). Lease.first_due_date() finds the first occurrence of due_day on or after the lease's start date, clipping to the last valid day of that month; Lease.total_due_to_date() then walks forward one billing period at a time, multiplying the period count by the monthly rent:

```
def _clip_day(self, year, month):
    return min(self.due_day, calendar.monthrange(year, month)[1])

def total_due_to_date(self, as_of=None):
    as_of = as_of or date.today()
    first_due = self.first_due_date()
    if as_of < first_due: return 0.0
    periods, due = 1, first_due
    while True:
        due = self._advance_month(due)
        if due > as_of: break
        periods += 1
    return round(periods * self.monthly_rent, 2)
```

The tenant's live balance is simply max(0, total_due_to_date() – total_paid), and never goes negative — an over-payment instead accumulates as credit, a separate computed property. This is verified directly in tests/test_models.py (mid-month start, day-29-in-a-non-leap-year, and overpayment cases).

5.5.2 Role-Based Access Control and IDOR Protection

Two separate, composable checks guard every sensitive route, matching the two different questions "is this role allowed to use this feature at all?" and "is this specific record this user's to see?":

```
def role_required(*roles):
    def decorator(view):
        @wraps(view)
        @login_required
        def wrapped(*a, **kw):
            if current_user().role not in roles: abort(403)
            return view(*a, **kw)
        return wrapped
    return decorator

def assert_owner(property_id):
    user = current_user()
    if user.role in (ROLE_ADMIN, ROLE_MANAGER):
        allowed = db.session.query(Property.id).filter(Property.id ==
property_id).scalar() is not None
    elif user.role == ROLE_OWNER:
        allowed = db.session.query(Property.id).filter(
Property.id == property_id, Property.owner_id == user.id).scalar() is not None
    else:
```

```

allowed = False
if not allowed: abort(403)

```

This combination is what lets a Property Manager see every property (a role-level allowance) while a second Property Owner is blocked from viewing the first owner's property even though both hold the PROPERTY_OWNER role — verified in tests/test_auth.py::test_idor_second_owner_cannot_view_first_owner_property.

5.5.3 Idempotent Numbering and Payment Recording

Receipt numbers (RCP-YYYYMMDD-HEX6) and maintenance ticket numbers (MNT-YYYYMMDD-XXXX) are generated from uuid4, not an incrementing counter, so concurrent creation never races on a shared "next number" value — verified by generating and de-duplicating 25 receipt numbers in a tight loop in the test suite. Online payments are additionally idempotent on the payment gateway's own reference: a webhook that is delivered twice (a known behaviour of most payment providers) looks up the existing RentPayment by gateway_ref before creating a new one.

5.5.4 Dev-Mode Fallback for External Services

Every integration with a paid external service — SendGrid, Twilio, Stripe — checks for its API key in configuration before doing anything else. When the key is absent (the default in development and in the test suite), the corresponding Notification row is still created and marked SENT, and the Stripe checkout flow redirects to the application's own confirmation route instead of a real gateway. This single design choice is what allows the entire application, including every payment and notification flow, to be demonstrated and automatically tested with zero external accounts or network access.

5.6 Security Implementation

Control	Implementation
Password hashing	Werkzeug generate_password_hash(), method="pbkdf2:sha256:600000"
Session management	Flask signed cookie sessions; SECRET_KEY required at startup
Account logout	MAX_FAILED_ATTEMPTS = 5 consecutive failures locks the account for 15 minutes
RBAC	role_required(*roles) decorator on every protected route; 5 roles
IDOR protection	assert_owner() / assert_tenant_self() — verified in tests/test_auth.py
CSRF protection	Flask-WTF CSRFProtect(), initialised inside create_app(); the Stripe webhook route is explicitly exempted via @csrf.exempt since it is called by Stripe, not a browser session
Open-redirect protection	The login next= parameter is validated with urlparse() — both netloc and scheme must be empty before it is used as a redirect target
Rate limiting	Flask-Limiter on /login (10/min) and /forgot-password (5/min)
Webhook signature verification	Custom HMAC-SHA256 check of a

Control	Implementation
	<code>t=<timestamp>,v1=<sig></code> header with a 300-second replay window, independent of the Stripe SDK's own verifier
File upload validation	<code>validate_upload()</code> reads the first bytes of the stream and requires the %PDF- magic number for any file claiming to be a PDF, regardless of its extension
Input validation	<code>validate()</code> enforces <code>positive_float</code> , <code>positive_int</code> , <code>email</code> , <code>date</code> , <code>min8</code> and <code>max200</code> rules on form input before any database write
Upload size cap	<code>MAX_CONTENT_LENGTH</code> caps every request body at 20 MB app-wide
Audit log	Every state-changing action writes an immutable <code>AuditLog</code> row via <code>audit_log()</code> , safe to call from a background job (<code>ip_address</code> is recorded as "scheduler")
Report data isolation	<code>/reports</code> and <code>/api/v1/reports/export</code> filter properties by <code>owner_id</code> for the Property Owner role, so one owner cannot see another owner's portfolio data

5.7 Deployment

5.7.1 Docker

The application ships with a `Dockerfile` and `docker-compose.yml` defining three services — `web` (Flask under Gunicorn), `db` (PostgreSQL 15), and `redis` (Redis 7). The container entrypoint waits for the database to accept connections, creates the schema (`flask create-db`), and seeds demo data (`flask seed-db`) before starting Gunicorn.

5.7.2 Continuous Integration

A GitHub Actions workflow (`.github/workflows/ci.yml`) runs on every push to `main` or `develop`: it installs dependencies, runs the full `pytest` suite with coverage, and — on `main` only — builds the Docker image and smoke-tests it by polling the `/health` endpoint until it responds or the job times out.

5.8 Implementation Defects Found and Fixed

Two genuine defects surfaced during development, both caught before release rather than in production:

#	Symptom	Root Cause	Fix
1	A <code>TemplateSyntaxError</code> on every failed-login, lockout, and logout page render	<code>auth/login.html</code> was missing its closing <code>{% endblock %}</code> tag	Closed the block; covered going forward by <code>tests/test_auth.py</code> exercising the wrong-password, lockout, and logout paths
2	A 500 error on <code>GET /api/v1/leases/<id>/statement</code>	The route ordered payments by <code>Lease.created_at</code> , a	Changed the <code>ORDER BY</code> to <code>RentPayment.paid_at</code> ; covered by

#	Symptom	Root Cause	Fix
		column that does not exist on that model	tests/test_routes.py::test_lease_statement_api_allowed_for_own_tenant

Chapter 6: Testing

6.1 Testing Strategy

RentalPro is verified with pytest, run against a fresh in-memory SQLite database created per test (no shared state between tests) and Flask's own test client, which issues real HTTP requests through the full middleware stack — session handling, CSRF (disabled in TestConfig for form simplicity), RBAC, and the ORM — rather than calling view functions directly. External services (SendGrid, Twilio, Stripe) are never called for real: the suite either relies on the dev-mode fallback described in Section 5.5.4, or monkeypatches the provider SDK to simulate a specific failure (Section 6.4).

6.2 Test Environment

Aspect	Configuration
Database	SQLite :memory:, created fresh per test via a function-scoped pytest fixture
CSRF	Disabled in TestConfig (WTF_CSRF_ENABLED = False) to keep test form posts simple
Scheduler	Disabled in TestConfig (SCHEDULER_ENABLED = False) — jobs are invoked directly by the test, not by APScheduler's background thread
Rate limiting	Disabled in TestConfig — irrelevant to the behaviour under test and would make repeated test runs flaky
External services	No API keys configured — every provider call goes through its dev-mode path unless a test explicitly monkeypatches it

6.3 Test Suite Structure

File	Tests	What It Verifies
tests/conftest.py	—	Shared fixtures: app/db/client, and factory fixtures for each role, a property, a unit, and an active lease
tests/test_models.py	18	Business logic: password hashing, full_name, occupancy_rate (incl. zero-division guard), balance never negative, total_paid accumulation, first_due_date edge cases (mid-month start, day-29 clipping), receipt/ticket number format and uniqueness under rapid creation, maintenance cost aggregation, overdue detection, invitation/reset-token validity
tests/test_auth.py	14	Login success/failure, account lockout after 5 attempts, role-based post-login redirect, RBAC

File	Tests	What It Verifies
		across all 5 roles × the management routes, IDOR (a second owner cannot view the first owner's property), Admin/Manager bypass, logout
tests/test_routes.py	16	End-to-end feature flows: property/unit creation, unit archiving (blocked vs. allowed), tenant creation and invitation, lease upload (incl. PDF rejection), payment recording, online payment, the full maintenance lifecycle, cost accumulation, reports page and JSON export
tests/test_scheduler.py	9	All 4 background jobs invoked directly: lease-expiry alert fires at exactly 30 days and is skipped at 100 days, rent-due alert fires at the 7/1-day thresholds and is skipped once paid, overdue alert creates a tenant notice plus an owner summary, maintenance escalation fires for an overdue assigned request and is skipped when closed or not yet due, and audit_log() works outside a request context
tests/test_validation.py	36	validate() for every kind (positive_float, positive_int, email, date, min8, max200) with valid and invalid cases; validate_upload() accepting a real PDF and rejecting a ZIP renamed to .pdf, a wrong extension, an empty filename, and None; Stripe HMAC signature verification (missing, tampered, expired, and valid); idempotent payment recording; SendGrid dispatch marking SENT with no provider configured and FAILED on a simulated provider error

6.4 Representative Test Cases

Two tests are reproduced here to illustrate the style used throughout: one exercising business logic directly, one exercising a full HTTP request/response cycle.

```
# tests/test_models.py
def test_lease_balance_never_negative_when_overpaid(db, active_lease):
    payment = RentPayment(lease_id=active_lease.id,
```

```

        amount=active_lease.monthly_rent * 10, method="CASH",
        receipt_number=RentPayment.generate_receipt_number(),
        recorded_by=active_lease.tenant.user_id)
    db.session.add(payment); db.session.commit()
    assert active_lease.balance == 0.0
    assert active_lease.credit > 0

# tests/test_routes.py
def test_maintenance_full_lifecycle(client, db, manager, staff, active_lease):
    login(client, active_lease.tenant.user.email)
    client.post("/maintenance/add", data={"title": "AC not cooling", ...})
    req = MaintenanceRequest.query.filter_by(title="AC not cooling").first()
    assert req.status == "SUBMITTED"
    login(client, manager.email)
    client.post(f"/maintenance/{req.id}/update",
               data={"action": "assign", "staff_id": staff.id, ...})
    assert req.status == "ASSIGNED" and req.assigned_to == staff.id
    # ... start, complete, then the tenant closes and rates the work ...
    assert req.status == "CLOSED" and req.satisfaction_rating == 5

```

6.5 Test Results

Metric	Result
Tests collected	93
Tests passed	93
Tests failed	0
Statement coverage (pytest --cov=backend)	77%
Roles exercised by test_auth.py	5 (Admin, Owner, Manager, Staff, Tenant)
Use cases with at least one covering test	25 / 25

Coverage is concentrated in `models.py` (98%), `security.py` (92%), and the reports service (93%) — the modules carrying the business rules this project cares most about proving correct. The lowest-coverage files are the thin route handlers whose branches are error-message formatting rather than business logic, and `backend/seed.py` (0%), which is demo-data tooling, not application behaviour, and is intentionally outside the test suite's scope.

6.6 Known Test Limitations

Two tests in `tests/test_scheduler.py` compute a `due_day` from "today" so that a lease's next or current due date lands on an exact, predictable day (e.g. exactly 7 days from now). Both self-skip via `pytest.skip()` when that computed day falls after the 28th of the month, because day-of-month clipping in a short month (Section 5.5.1) could otherwise shift the actual due date by a day and make the assertion's premise wrong rather than its conclusion. This is a deliberate, documented trade-off for keeping the suite deterministic year-round rather than a gap in coverage.

6.7 How to Run the Test Suite

```

pip install -r requirements.txt
pytest tests/ -v                                     # all 93 tests

```

```
pytest tests/ --cov=backend --cov-report=term-missing # with coverage
pytest tests/test_models.py -v                      # a single file
pytest tests/test_models.py::test_receipt_number_format -v # a single test
```

The suite runs fully offline: no database server, external API key, or network access is required, consistent with the dev-mode design described in Section 5.5.4.

Chapter 7: Conclusion

7.1 Summary of Achievements

RentalPro was carried from a requirements document (IT401 Deliverable 1) through a design (IT401 Deliverable 2) to a working, tested application (IT401 Deliverable 3) and now this complete project report (IT402 Deliverable 1). Every one of the 25 use cases identified during analysis has a corresponding route or scheduled job, a template, and at least one automated test; the 13-table database design was implemented exactly as specified, with the two documented, deliberate substitutions (UUID-as-string primary keys and reportlab in place of WeasyPrint) covered in Chapters 1, 3, and 4. The application runs — and its 93-test suite passes at 77% statement coverage — using only Docker, or a local Python virtual environment, with zero paid external accounts required.

7.2 Challenges Encountered

- Reconciling the earlier, aspirational design documents (IT401 Deliverable 2's microservice-style package diagram, IT401 Deliverable 3's originally-stated test and coverage numbers) with what a single developer could actually build and verify in the time available — resolved by simplifying the architecture to a layered monolith (Chapter 3) and, when IT401 Deliverable 3 was found to overstate its own results, correcting it to the real, verified numbers rather than leaving the discrepancy in place.
- Getting recurring, calendar-based billing logic (Section 5.5.1) correct at month boundaries — a lease starting on the 31st, or due on a day that doesn't exist in February — required writing the edge-case tests before trusting the implementation.
- Keeping the whole system, including payments and notifications, testable without any live external account. This shaped the dev-mode fallback pattern used throughout the services layer (Section 5.5.4).

7.3 Limitations

These are carried forward from Section 1.5 and restated here against the finished system, now that they are verified facts rather than anticipated risks:

- File uploads are stored on local disk, not cloud object storage; this is adequate for a single-container deployment but would need revisiting before a multi-instance production deployment.
- No formal Alembic migration history exists yet — schema changes so far have been applied by recreating the schema (flask create-db), which is acceptable pre-launch but would need a real migration path before a live database held real tenant data.
- The system is single-currency-per-property but not yet multi-language in the UI, despite the data model supporting per-property currency.
- Payment, email, and SMS providers have only been exercised through their dev-mode fallback and unit-level signature/idempotency tests; a real Stripe/SendGrid/Twilio account has not been used end-to-end.

7.4 Future Work

The following work is planned for the rest of IT402 (IT Capstone II):

- Real cloud file storage (S3-compatible) for lease documents and photos, replacing the local uploads/ directory.
- An administrator-facing dashboard for the ADMIN role, which currently has full data access but no dedicated UI beyond the existing owner/manager views.
- A mobile-optimised tenant portal, given that tenants are the role most likely to use the system from a phone.
- Alembic-based schema migrations, replacing the create_all() bootstrap used during initial development.
- End-to-end verification against live Stripe, SendGrid, and Twilio sandbox accounts, in addition to the existing offline test suite.

7.5 Final Remarks

The guiding principle across every deliverable so far has been that a claim in this report should be a fact about the running system, not a target for it. Every number in this document — 25 use cases, 13 tables, 93 tests, 77% coverage — was produced by actually running the code, not by estimating what a finished version would show. That discipline is, in the author's view, as much a deliverable of this capstone as the application itself.

Appendix A: Installation Guide

A.1 Prerequisites

Requirement	Notes
Docker & Docker Compose	Recommended path — no local Python setup needed
— or — Python 3.12	For running without Docker
Git	To clone the repository
Nothing else is required	SendGrid / Twilio / Stripe accounts are optional — the app runs fully offline without them (Section 5.5.4)

A.2 Option 1 — Docker (Recommended)

This is the fastest path to a running instance with demo data already loaded.

```
# 1. Clone the repository
git clone https://github.com/Abdur-lab/github-slideshow.git
cd github-slideshow

# 2. Copy the environment template and set a secret key
cp env.example .env
# edit .env and set SECRET_KEY to a random value, e.g.:
# python -c "import secrets; print(secrets.token_hex(32))"

# 3. Build and start the full stack (Flask + PostgreSQL + Redis)
docker compose up --build

# 4. Open the application
# http://localhost:5000
```

The container entrypoint automatically waits for PostgreSQL to accept connections, creates the schema, and seeds demo accounts (Section A.5) the first time it runs.

A.3 Option 2 — Local Installation (Without Docker)

```
git clone https://github.com/Abdur-lab/github-slideshow.git
cd github-slideshow

python -m venv venv
source venv/bin/activate          # Windows: venv\Scripts\activate

pip install -r requirements.txt

export SECRET_KEY=$(python -c "import secrets; print(secrets.token_hex(32))")
export DATABASE_URL=sqlite:///rentalpro.db

flask create-db                   # creates the 13 tables
flask seed-db                     # loads demo accounts and sample data
```

```
python app.py
# App running at http://localhost:5000
```

A.4 Environment Variables

Variable	Required?	Purpose
SECRET_KEY	Yes	Flask session signing key
DATABASE_URL	No (defaults to local SQLite)	e.g. postgresql://user:pass@host:5432/db
REDIS_URL	No	Enables Redis-backed caching; falls back to in-memory otherwise
SENDGRID_API_KEY	No	Real email delivery; unset = dev-mode (logged as SENT)
TWILIO_ACCOUNT_SID / TWILIO_AUTH_TOKEN / TWILIO_FROM_NUMBER	No	Real SMS delivery; unset = dev-mode
STRIPE_SECRET_KEY / STRIPE_WEBHOOK_SECRET	No	Real online payments; unset = simulated checkout
UPLOAD_FOLDER	No	Where lease PDFs are stored locally (default ./uploads)
SCHEDULER_ENABLED	No (default true)	Set to false to disable the 4 background jobs

A.5 Demo Credentials

Seeded automatically by flask seed-db (local) or on first container start (Docker):

Email	Password	Role
owner@rentalpro.com	demo123	Property Owner — full management access
manager@rentalpro.com	demo123	Property Manager — management, cannot create properties
tenant1@email.com	demo123	Tenant — self-service portal only
staff@rentalpro.com	demo123	Maintenance Staff — work queue only

A.6 Running the Test Suite

```
pytest tests/ -v
pytest tests/ --cov=backend --cov-report=term-missing
```

A.7 Troubleshooting

Symptom	Likely Cause / Fix
"SECRET_KEY required" on startup	Set the SECRET_KEY environment variable before starting the app
Login page loops back to itself	Check the demo credentials in Section A.5 exactly, including the domain in the email
docker compose up fails to reach the database	Wait a few seconds and retry — the entrypoint script retries the DB connection for up to 30 seconds before failing
File upload rejected as "not a signed lease PDF"	The uploaded file's first bytes must be %PDF- (Section 5.6); a renamed non-PDF file will be rejected by design
Emails / SMS "not arriving"	Expected when SENDGRID_API_KEY / TWILIO_* are unset — check the Notification table (or the admin's inbox in a future release) rather than a real inbox

Appendix B: User Manual

B.1 Getting Started

Open the application in a browser and sign in at the login page with the email and password given to you by your property owner or manager (or one of the demo accounts in Appendix A.5, for evaluation). Every screen after login shows a sidebar scoped to your role — you will only ever see navigation links for actions you are permitted to perform.

If you forget your password, use "Forgot your password?" on the login page. A reset link valid for one hour will be emailed to you (or, in a demo/offline deployment, logged as sent — see Appendix A.4).

B.2 Property Owner & Property Manager Guide

Owners and Managers share almost the same view of the system. The one difference: only an Owner can create a brand-new property (Section B.2.1); a Manager works within properties an Owner has already added.

B.2.1 Add a Property

- From the sidebar, choose Properties, then "+ Add New Property".
- Enter the property name, address, city, country, type, and currency.
- Save — the system assigns a unique property code (PROP-XXXX) automatically.

B.2.2 Add a Unit

- Open the property, then "+ Add Unit".
- Enter the unit number, floor, type, size, monthly rent, and deposit.
- Save — the unit starts as VACANT with an auto-generated unit code.

B.2.3 Onboard a Tenant

There are two ways to bring a tenant into the system:

- **Create the profile directly:** from the vacant unit, choose "Create Tenant Profile" and fill in the tenant's details yourself. Use this when the tenant will not self-register.
- **Send an invitation link:** from the vacant unit, choose "Invite Tenant", enter their name and email, and the system emails them a secure link (valid 48 hours) to set up their own account and password.

B.2.4 Upload a Lease and Activate a Tenancy

- Open the tenant's profile and choose "Upload Lease Document".
- Select the vacant unit, enter the lease dates, monthly rent, deposit, and the day of the month rent is due.
- Upload the signed lease as a PDF (the system checks the file is a genuine PDF, not just named .pdf).
- Save — the unit changes to OCCUPIED and the tenant receives a confirmation email.

B.2.5 Record a Rent Payment

- From Rent Tracker, choose "Record Payment" (or start from a specific tenant's profile).
- Select the tenant, enter the amount, method, and date.
- Save — a receipt number is generated, the tenant's balance updates immediately, and a receipt email is sent.

B.2.6 Generate a Rent Statement

From a tenant's profile, choose "Generate Statement" to see an on-screen statement for the lease, or "Download PDF" for a printable version covering all charges and payments to date.

B.2.7 Manage a Maintenance Request

- Open Maintenance to see every request across your properties (or one property's worth, if you opened it from there).
- Open a SUBMITTED request and choose a staff member plus a target completion date to assign it.
- Once the assigned staff member marks it Completed, you may log the cost(s) incurred against the ticket from the same page.
- If a tenant does not confirm or reopen a completed request, you may force-close it from the same page.

B.2.8 View Reports

Open Reports to see portfolio-wide occupancy, rent collection, outstanding balances, and maintenance cost — or select a single property from the dropdown for its own figures. Use "Export PDF" for a printable report.

B.3 Tenant Guide

As a tenant you have your own portal, separate from the management views above. You can only ever see your own lease, payments, and maintenance requests.

B.3.1 Your Dashboard

After logging in you land on your dashboard, showing your unit, monthly rent, current balance, recent payments, and your maintenance requests.

B.3.2 Pay Rent Online

- From the sidebar, choose "Pay Rent".
- Confirm the amount shown (your current balance) and click "Pay Now".
- You will receive an emailed receipt once the payment is confirmed, and your balance updates immediately.

B.3.3 View Your Payment History

Choose "Payment History" to see every payment you have made against your lease, with its date, amount, method, and receipt number.

B.3.4 Submit a Maintenance Request

- Choose "Submit Request" from the sidebar or your dashboard.
- Enter a title, choose a category and severity, and describe the issue.
- Submit — you will receive a ticket number by email, and your property manager is notified immediately (with an SMS alert too, if you marked the issue as Emergency).
- You may have at most 5 open requests at a time.

B.3.5 Respond to a Completed Request

When your maintenance request is marked Completed, open it from your dashboard. You may either Confirm Resolution (optionally rating the work 1–5 stars), which closes the ticket, or Reopen Request with a reason if the issue is not actually fixed, which sends it back to your property manager for reassignment.

B.4 Maintenance Staff Guide

As Maintenance Staff you see only your own work queue — requests assigned specifically to you.

- Open Maintenance to see your assigned requests.
- Open a request and choose "Mark In Progress" once you begin work.
- When finished, add work notes describing what was done and choose "Mark Completed".
- You cannot see any other role's data — properties, tenants, rent, and reports are not part of your view.

B.5 Common Questions

Question	Answer
Why can't I create a new property as a Manager?	Property creation is Owner-only by design (Section 2.2) — ask the property owner to add it, then it will be available to you.
Why is a unit still showing as Vacant after I invited a tenant?	The unit only becomes Occupied once a lease document is uploaded and activated (Section B.2.4) — an accepted invitation alone creates the tenant's account but not yet a lease.
Can I edit a payment I recorded by mistake?	No — payment records are permanent by design (Section 5.6). Record a correcting entry instead and note the reason.
Why did my maintenance request get reassigned automatically?	It didn't — but if its target completion date passes without being marked Completed, the system flags it as overdue and alerts the property manager (UC-23); nothing changes on your end.

Appendix C: Updates Since the Main Report (October 2026)

This section brings the document up to date. Chapters 1–7 and Appendices A–B describe RentalPro as it stood when they were written, and their figures are deliberately left as they were at that time. Since then, eleven gaps against the SRS have been closed for IT402 Deliverable 2, and the system has gained a billing engine, a property map, a redesigned interface, English, Shona and Arabic interface languages, Harare demonstration data, a tenant history page for each unit and a maintenance summary report, full Arabic and production hardening, and finally deployment to Render. Each change was made additively, behind the existing test suite, with new tests of its own.

C.1 Summary of Changes

Area	What changed	New tests
IT402 Deliverable 2	Eleven gaps against the SRS closed: editing units; property, unit and maintenance photos; tenant ID documents; lease document download; tenant blacklisting; administrator user and role management; staff account creation; configurable late fees; CSV and Excel exports.	31
Billing engine	Charges and sundries, electricity metering, pro rata first month, variable/escalating rent, automated recurring billing (a fifth scheduler job), statements by period, PDF payment receipts, and property expenses with net income. Five new tables: lease_charges, meter_readings, rent_revisions, rent_invoices, property_expenses.	79
Property map	Map coordinates on each property, set by clicking a map on the Add/Edit forms; a pin on the property page and a portfolio map at /properties/map. Leaflet is bundled with the app, not loaded from a CDN.	8
Interface redesign	The sidebar was replaced by a horizontal top navigation bar. The login page is a full-screen photograph of the Harare skyline, and each section of the app has its own Harare photograph behind it, with solid white cards and white page titles.	—
Languages	A language menu in the top bar and on the login page shows the current language and opens a list of English, ChiShona and Arabic; a small translator (backend/i18n.py) with an English fallback; Arabic pages switch to a right-to-left layout; the choice survives logging in and out. Names and places are never translated.	14
Tenant unit labels	The tenant dashboard and Pay Rent page show “Avondale Heights · Unit 101” instead of the internal unit code.	1
Logged-in redirect	Opening the home page, the login page, a reset link or an invitation link while signed in now goes to the user's own home page instead of an empty page.	4
Harare demo data	Five properties in Avondale, the CBD, Eastlea and Vainona with map coordinates; 16 units; nine tenants with Zimbabwean names, national IDs and +263 phone numbers; payment histories with three tenants in arrears; the administrator account Abdur-Rahmaan Ali.	—
History & summary	A History page on every unit lists each tenant who has occupied it, newest first (FR-015); the Reports page has a Maintenance Summary of open, in-progress and closed requests per property for a chosen period (FR-036).	13

Area	What changed	New tests
Full Arabic & hardening	Arabic on every page, message, email, SMS and PDF; each user's language saved; every amount with its currency; security headers and a required secret key; Alembic database migrations; optional S3-compatible file storage.	54
Cloud deployment	render.yaml deploys the Docker image and a PostgreSQL database to Render, the cloud host planned in IT401 Deliverable 3, served over HTTPS. Behind the host's proxy the app recognises HTTPS and each visitor's own address (TRUST_FORWARDED_PROTO and CLIENT_IP_HEADER, both off by default), database URLs name the installed PostgreSQL driver, and only one Gunicorn worker runs the background jobs.	7

C.2 Current Figures

Figure	In Chapters 1-7	Now (October 2026)
Database tables	13	18
Jinja2 templates	31	40
Route blueprints	9	10
Background scheduler jobs	4	5
Test modules	5	22
Automated tests	93	305
Statement coverage	77%	86%
Interface languages	1 (English)	3 (English, Shona, Arabic)

All 305 tests pass with no failures, and the suite still runs entirely offline, with no paid external account needed.

C.3 Language Support and the SRS

The SRS described multi-language support as Arabic and English. Both are now implemented, together with Shona. Shona, the most widely spoken language in Harare, serves the landlords, managers and tenants the system was built for; Arabic, the second language the SRS named, serves Arabic-speaking residents and property owners in Zimbabwe. Each language is only another phrase table, so a further language, such as Ndebele, can be added the same way.

- **How it works:** Templates wrap interface text in _("..."); backend/i18n.py looks each phrase up in the table for the chosen language — the Arabic table covers all 613 phrases the app shows or sends, the Shona table the 98 on the main screens — and falls back to English for anything not yet translated, so the app works at every stage of translation.
- **Right-to-left layout:** Arabic is written from right to left, so an Arabic page is marked dir="rtl" and the browser mirrors the layout: the navigation starts from the right and table columns read from right to left (Figure 6), and on the login page the RentalPro name and the language menu swap

corners. The stylesheet aligns text to the start of the line rather than to a fixed left or right, so one stylesheet serves both directions. English and Shona stay left to right.

- **Choosing a language:** A language button in the top bar and on the login page shows the current language; clicking its arrow opens a vertical list of English, ChiShona and Arabic, each written in its own language. The list closes on a click elsewhere or the Escape key. The choice survives logging in and out and is saved to the user's account, so it follows them to any browser and their emails and SMS are written in it; the menu's return address is checked so it cannot redirect off-site.
- **Translated:** Arabic covers every page, form option and message, every email and SMS, the PDFs (with joined, right-to-left letters) and the Excel and CSV exports; a test fails if any text the app shows or sends has no Arabic. Shona covers navigation for every role, login and password reset, the dashboards, the main list pages, the tenant portal and status badges; other Shona text falls back to English.
- **Never translated:** Property names, addresses, suburbs, cities and people's names are data, not interface text, and read the same in every language; a test fails if a Harare place name is altered in Shona or Arabic, or given an entry in either phrase table.
- **Tests:** Fourteen tests cover the languages: switching to Shona and to Arabic, the right-to-left direction for Arabic only, the choice surviving login, the tenant portal in Shona and in Arabic, the language menu, unknown language codes, off-site redirects, placeholders kept in every translation, Arabic covering every Shona phrase, and place names. Later tests check that every phrase the app shows or sends has Arabic, and that emails, SMS, PDFs, Excel and CSV follow the reader's language.
- **Caveat:** The Shona and Arabic wording has not yet been reviewed by native speakers.

C.4 The Current Interface

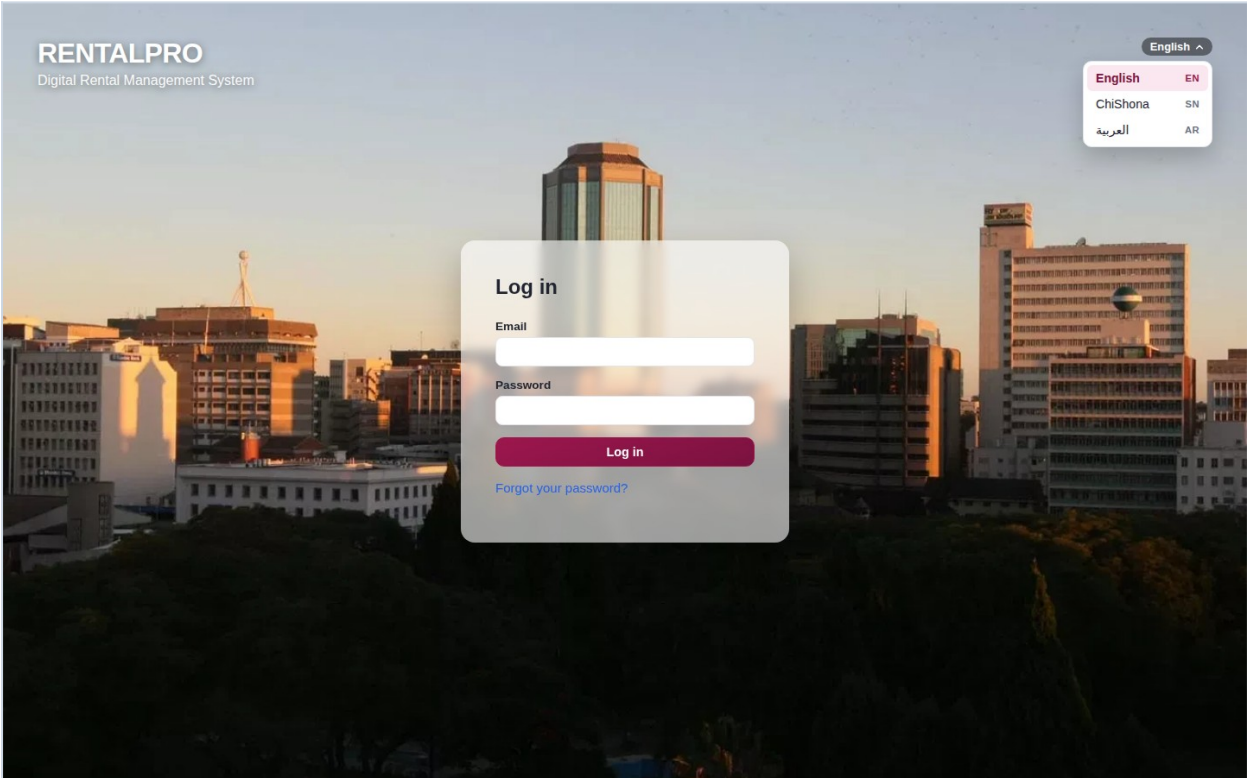


Figure 4: The login page — Harare skyline, translucent card and the language menu, opened

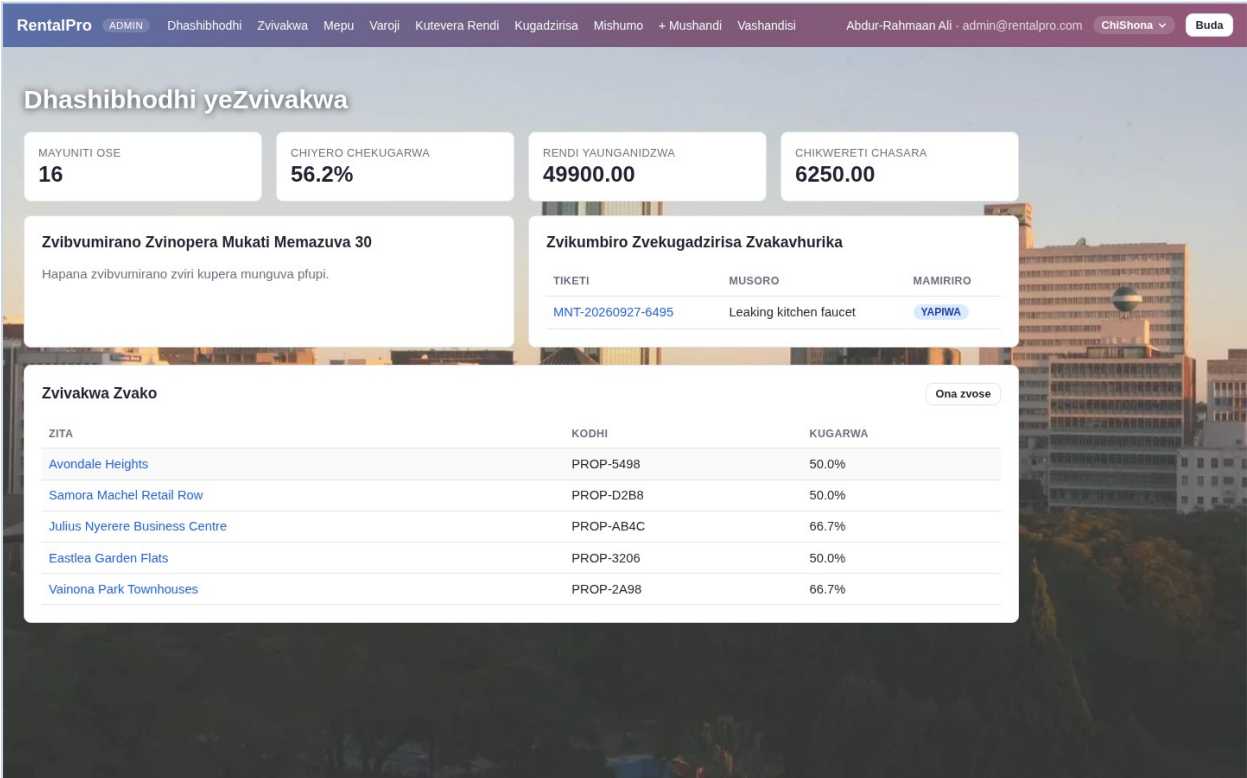


Figure 5: The portfolio dashboard in Shona — names and places stay as entered

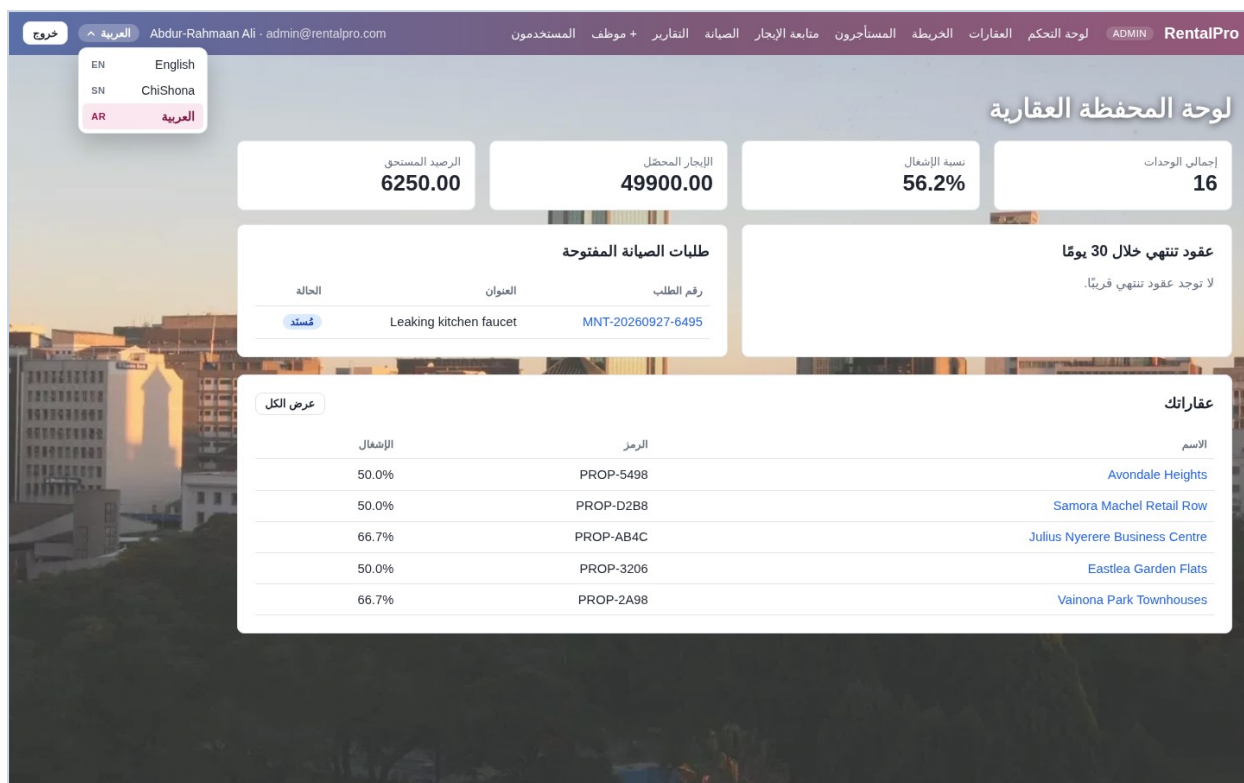


Figure 6: The portfolio dashboard in Arabic — the layout reads right to left and the language menu is open

Choosing a language (addition to Appendix B): click the language button at the top right of any page or of the login page (top left when the page is in Arabic), then pick English, ChiShona or Arabic from the list. The choice stays in place until you change it again.

Managing users (addition to Appendix B): the administrator (admin@rentalpro.com in the demo data) chooses Manage Users in the top bar to see every account with its role and status. To change a role, or to deactivate an account so it can no longer sign in, change the Role or untick Active on that row and choose Save; the change is recorded in the audit log and the user is emailed. + Add Staff creates a Maintenance Staff account and emails the new staff member a link to set a password. The system refuses any change that would leave no active Property Owner.

C.5 Updated Demo Accounts and Data

All demo accounts use the password demo123. The seed data only loads into an empty database; delete rentalpro.db (or the Postgres volume) to reload it.

Email	Name	Role
admin@rentalpro.com	Abdur-Rahmaan Ali	Administrator
owner@rentalpro.com	Tendai Moyo	Property Owner
manager@rentalpro.com	Rutendo Chikore	Property Manager
staff@rentalpro.com	Farai Ncube	Maintenance Staff
tenant1@email.com	Chipo Mutasa	Tenant (Avondale Heights, Unit 101)
tenant2@email.com ... tenant9@email.com	Eight further Harare tenants	Tenants across all five properties